Stimuli and Scenario

Joël Sieber
University of St.Gallen (HSG)

Supplementary Materials

Scenario text

Imagine you are a student in Medellín and currently renting a room in an apartment you share with two other people. Over the past few weeks, your financial situation has become tighter, and you're starting to notice that you might not be able to pay the full rent for next month. Soon you'll have to decide how to move forward.

While searching for information online, you come across an announcement from an NGO that offers advice and guidance on affordable housing options or housing with some form of subsidy. It seems like it could be relevant to your situation. At the same time, you're unsure whether your case is "significant enough" or whether this kind of support is meant for people facing much more difficult circumstances.

Before contacting someone directly or filling out a form, you'd prefer to first find out informally whether it makes sense to approach this NGO. On their website, there's a chatbot that provides initial information. You open the chat to get oriented.

Please read the following messages as if you were genuinely deciding, right now, whether to take the next step and reach out to the NGO.

Note: *The scenario and stimuli were developed on the basis of the accompanying Stimulus-Construction Protocol, which specifies the conceptual framework and design principles guiding stimulus development. The materials were originally created in Spanish and reviewed in consultation with Plan International Colombia as part of this process.*

The English version presented here is a direct translation of the original Spanish materials and is provided for transparency and documentation purposes. Minor linguistic irregularities may occur due to the literal translation.

The Spanish version constitutes the original experimental stimuli used in the study. The Stimulus-Construction Protocol documents the development procedure and validation considerations.

Condition 1: Neutral / Low Empathy - Low Recognition (LL)

Turn 1

User:
Hello. I saw your announcement. I am currently studying in Medellín and have noticed that paying my rent could become difficult in the coming months. I am not sure whether your offer is intended for a situation like mine.

Bot:
Hello. I can provide general information about the activities of the NGO and how the initial contact works.

Would you like to see a general overview of the support offered, or check whether your situation falls within the scope of the NGO?

User:
I would first like to understand what you offer.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I prefer to check whether this fits my situation.

Turn 2

User:
Showing general information.

User:
Showing eligibility criteria and scope.

Turn 3

Bot:
The NGO supports students and young adults who experience difficulties maintaining their current housing situation or finding affordable housing. The support may include initial orientation conversations, advice, or referrals to existing programs. There is no automatic decision at this stage.

The process begins with an assessment of the situation, which may include reviewing possible options such as short-term relief, alternative housing options, or counseling services.

Turn 4

User:
I am not at immediate risk of eviction, but I am not sure whether I will be able to pay the full rent next month, and the following months will also be financially difficult. That is why I am not sure whether I should contact you.

Bot:
This type of situation can be reviewed during an initial assessment. The purpose of the first contact is to collect information about the current circumstances and identify possible next steps.

Turn 5

Bot:
Would you like to receive information about how an initial conversation works, or see more concretely which types of support might be relevant?

User:
Please briefly explain how an initial conversation works.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I would like to see more concretely what might be relevant.

Turn 6

Bot:
Show details of the initial conversation.

Bot:
Showing relevant support options.

Turn 7

Bot:
During this conversation, the current housing situation is discussed and possible options are described. The conversation may remain general or focus on individual circumstances.

Turn 8

Bot:
To evaluate which support options may be relevant, certain personal information may be requested.

User:
Alex García
(*Name)*

OR

User:
301-249-1243
(*Phone number)*

OR

User:
1.752.236.861
(*ID number)*

OR

User:
I don't want to provide any of this information.

Turn 9

Bot:
Understood.

Turn 10

Bot:
Would you like to initiate contact with the NGO?

User:
Yes, I would like to initiate contact.

OR
(User choice)

User:
No, not at the moment.

Condition 2: High Empathy - Low Recognition (HL)

Turn 1

User:
Hello. I saw your announcement. I am currently studying in Medellín and have noticed that paying my rent could become difficult in the coming months. I am not sure whether your offer is intended for a situation like mine.

Bot:
Hello. I understand very well that a housing-related situation like this can feel very heavy. Going through something like this is not easy, and it is common to feel uncertain or not know exactly what to do next. I am here to help you review the available information and accompany you while we explore together what options might exist ♡

Would you prefer to start with a brief general overview, or review directly whether your situation might fit the support offered by the NGO?

User:
I would first like to understand what you offer.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I prefer to check whether this fits my situation.

Turn 2

Bot:
Of course ☺ Let's start with a brief overview so that everything feels a little clearer.

Bot:
Of course ☺ Let's first look at how situations like this are usually evaluated, step by step, so that everything becomes a little clearer.

Turn 3

Bot:
The NGO supports students and young adults who experience difficulties maintaining their current housing situation or finding affordable housing. The support may include initial orientation conversations, advice, or referrals to existing programs. There is no automatic decision at this stage.

The process usually begins with an assessment of the situation to explore possible options, such as short-term relief, alternative housing options, or counseling services.

Turn 4

User:
I am not at immediate risk of eviction, but I am not sure whether I will be able to pay the full rent next month, and the following months will also be financially difficult. That is why I am not sure whether I should contact you.

Bot:
Thank you for sharing that with me. I understand that you may feel uncertain and that you might not yet be sure what the next step should be.

This type of situation is normally reviewed during an initial assessment. In cases like this, many people find it helpful to review the situation in more detail in order to understand what options might exist.

Turn 5

Bot:
We can go through this calmly, step by step. Would you like to first learn how an initial conversation with the NGO usually works, or would you prefer to explore which types of support might be relevant for your situation?

User:
Please briefly explain how an initial conversation works.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I would like to see more concretely what might be relevant.

Turn 6

Bot:
With pleasure 😊 I will briefly explain what that first exchange usually looks like so that you have a clearer idea.

Bot:
With pleasure 😊 I can show you what type of support might be relevant.

Turn 7

Bot:
During this first contact, the current housing situation is discussed and possible options are described. The conversation may remain general or focus on individual circumstances.

Turn 8

Bot:
Thinking about sharing personal information in a situation like this can sometimes create discomfort or doubts ♡

Many people feel something similar at this point in the conversation.

User:
Alex García
(*Name)*

OR

User:
301-249-1243
(*Phone number)*

OR

User:
1.752.236.861
(*ID number)*

OR

User:
I don't want to provide any of this information.

Turn 9

Bot:
Understood. Thank you for indicating that.

Turn 10

Bot:
Making a decision in a situation like this can raise many doubts. After reviewing information about housing or institutional support, it is not always easy to immediately decide what to do, and that is completely understandable.

Would you like to initiate contact with the NGO to explore possible support options?

User:
Yes, I would like to initiate contact.

OR
(User choice)

User:
No, not at the moment.

Condition 3: Low Empathy - High Recognition (LH)

Turn 1

User:
Hello. I saw your announcement. I am currently studying in Medellín and have noticed that paying my rent could become difficult in the coming months. I am not sure whether your offer is intended for a situation like mine.

Bot:
Hello. My function is to provide initial information about the scope of the NGO and explain how the first contact works. This conversation does not initiate any formal process. After reviewing the information, you decide whether you would like to continue or not.

Would you like to see a general overview first, or review the eligibility criteria?

User:
I would first like to understand what you offer.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I prefer to check whether this fits my situation.

Turn 2

Bot:
Okay. I will first show a general overview.

Bot:
Okay. I will first review the eligibility criteria.

Turn 3

Bot:
The NGO supports students and young adults who experience difficulties maintaining their current housing situation or finding affordable housing. The support may include initial orientation conversations, advice, or referrals to existing programs. There is no automatic decision at this stage.

The process begins with an assessment of the situation, which may include reviewing possible options such as short-term relief, alternative housing options, or counseling services.

Turn 4

User:
I am not at immediate risk of eviction, but I am not sure whether I will be able to pay the full rent next month, and the following months will also be financially difficult. That is why I am not sure whether I should contact you.

Bot:
This type of situation can be addressed in an initial assessment. The purpose of the first contact is to clarify the situation and review possible options. Participating at this stage does not imply any obligation.

Turn 5

Bot:
Would you like to receive information about how the initial conversation works, or about which types of support might be relevant?

User:
Please briefly explain how an initial conversation works.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I would like to see more concretely what might be relevant.

Turn 6

Bot:
The initial conversation serves to review the situation and present possible options.

Bot:
Different types of support can be reviewed depending on the situation described during the initial conversation.

Turn 7

Bot:
An initial contact is usually non-binding. During this conversation, the current housing situation is discussed and possible options are described. The conversation may remain general or focus on individual circumstances.

My role here is informational and orientational. I do not replace direct consultation with the NGO and I do not make decisions on your behalf.

Turn 8

Bot:
Some personal information may help determine which options could be relevant. Sharing this information is optional. You may also continue without providing it.

User:
Alex García
(*Name)*

OR

User:
301-249-1243
(*Phone number)*

OR

User:
1.752.236.861
(*ID number)*

OR

User:
I don't want to provide any of this information.

Turn 9

Bot:
Understood.

Turn 10

Bot:
You decide whether you would like to initiate contact with the NGO at this moment or not. Both options are valid.

Would you like to initiate contact?

User:
Yes, I would like to initiate contact.

OR
(User choice)

User:
No, not at the moment.

Condition 4: High Empathy – High Recognition (HH)

Turn 1

User:
Hello. I saw your announcement. I am currently studying in Medellín and have noticed that paying my rent could become difficult in the coming months. I am not sure whether your offer is intended for a situation like mine.

Bot:
Hello. I understand very well that a housing-related situation like this can feel very heavy. Going through something like this is not easy, and it is common to feel uncertain or not know exactly what to do next.

My function is to provide initial information about the scope of the NGO and explain how the first contact works. This conversation does not initiate any formal process. After reviewing the information, you decide whether you would like to continue or not.

Would you prefer to start with a brief general overview, or review directly whether your situation might fit the support offered by the NGO?

User:
I would first like to understand what you offer.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I prefer to check whether this fits my situation.

Turn 2

Bot:
Of course 😊 Let's start with a brief overview so that everything feels a little clearer.

Bot:
Of course 😊 Let's first look at how situations like this are usually evaluated, step by step, so that everything becomes a little clearer.

Turn 3

Bot:
The NGO supports students and young adults who experience difficulties maintaining their current housing situation or finding affordable housing. The support may include initial orientation conversations, advice, or referrals to existing programs. There is no automatic decision at this stage.

The process begins with an assessment of the situation, which may include reviewing possible options such as short-term relief, alternative housing options, or counseling services.

Turn 4

User:
I am not at immediate risk of eviction, but I am not sure whether I will be able to pay the full rent next month, and the following months will also be financially difficult. That is why I am not sure whether I should contact you.

Bot:
Thank you for sharing that. I understand that you may feel uncertain and that you might not yet be sure what the next step should be.

This type of situation can be addressed in an initial assessment. The purpose of the first contact is to clarify the situation and review possible options. Participating at this stage does not imply any obligation.

In cases like this, many people find it helpful to review the situation in more detail in order to understand what options might exist.

Turn 5

Bot:
We can review this calmly. Would you like to first learn how an initial conversation with the NGO usually works, or would you prefer to explore which types of support might be relevant for your situation?

User:
Please briefly explain how an initial conversation works.

OR
(User choice)

User:
I would like to see more concretely what might be relevant.

Turn 6

Bot:
With pleasure ☺ I will briefly explain what that first exchange usually looks like so that you have a clearer idea.

Bot:
With pleasure ☺ I can show you what type of support might be relevant.

Turn 7

Bot:
An initial contact is usually non-binding. During this conversation, the current housing situation is discussed and possible options are described. The conversation may remain general or focus on individual circumstances.

My role here is informational and orientational. I do not replace direct consultation with the NGO and I do not make decisions on your behalf.

Turn 8

Bot:
Thinking about sharing personal information in a situation like this can sometimes create discomfort or doubts ♡

Some personal information may help determine which options could be relevant. Sharing this information is optional. You may also continue without providing it.

User:
Alex García
(*Name)*

OR

User:
301-249-1243
(*Phone number)*

OR

User:
1.752.236.861
(*ID number)*

OR

User:
I don't want to provide any of this information.

Turn 9

Bot:
Understood. Thank you for indicating that.

Turn 10

Bot:
Making a decision in a situation like this can raise many doubts. After reviewing information about housing or institutional support, it is not always easy to immediately decide what to do, and that is completely understandable.

You decide whether you would like to initiate contact with the NGO at this moment or not. Both options are valid.
Would you like to initiate contact with the NGO to explore possible support options?

User:
Yes, I would like to initiate contact.

OR
(User choice)

User:
No, not at the moment.